

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE GRANDMASTER

Two women-oriented welfare schemes—Ladli Behna, launched in January this year in Madhya Pradesh, and Mahtari Vandan, a poll promise in Chhattisgarh—are being credited for the BJP's massive victory in these heartland states. The buzz is that the brain behind the two schemes was Union home minister **Amit Shah**, who had been impressed by a similar programme rolled out in Assam in 2020. Last year, he instructed Assam chief minister **Himanta Biswa Sarma** to work with the MP government on a similar model. Sarma and his officials met their counterparts Shivraj Singh Chouhan and his men to explain the modalities of the Arunodoi scheme, which provisions Rs 1,250 a month for the oldest woman in a household—exactly what Ladli Behna offers.

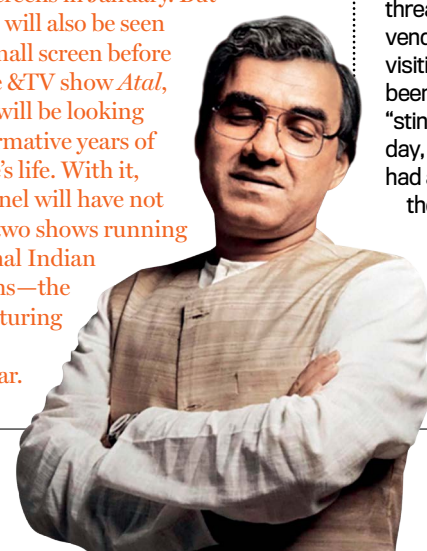
A GOOD GAMBLE



Revanth Reddy isn't the only Congress leader gloating over the party's stupendous victory in the Telangana assembly election. **Manickam Tagore**, whose role as AICC in-charge for Telangana was cut short in January, also has an I-told-you-so glow on his face these days. The change of guard had happened after a section of state leaders went up in arms over Revanth's "style of functioning". They had alleged that Tagore's blind backing had made the state Congress president arrogant. As a compromise formula, Tagore suggested to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi that he would quit, but insisted that Revanth must be allowed to continue. Keeping the faith eventually pays rich dividends, it seems.

MAN OF THE MOMENT

With the late **A.B. Vajpayee**'s 100th birth anniversary just weeks away, Atal season has begun in earnest, at least in entertainment. **Pankaj Tripathi** will be playing the poet-politician and ex-prime minister in *Main Atal Hoon*, which will hit the big screens in January. But Vajpayee will also be seen on the small screen before that. The &TV show *Atal*, though, will be looking at the formative years of Vajpayee's life. With it, the channel will have not one but two shows running on seminal Indian politicians—the other featuring Dr B.R. Ambedkar.





TREASURE TROVE

When NCP chief Sharad Pawar's trusted aide **Praful Patel** broke ranks in July, most people were confounded considering the camaraderie between the two. Since then, Patel has been dropping hints about how his former boss had kept lines open with the BJP while being an ally of the Congress. Now, Patel says he is writing a tell-all book that will reveal more unknown nuggets.



Colour Me Saffron

It looked like the victorious BJP had started showing its 'true colours' from day one in Rajasthan. On December 4, a mace-wielding **Mahant Balmukund Acharya**, who won the Hawamahal seat in Jaipur by just 974 votes, went around the Muslim-populated areas in his constituency threatening shopkeepers and vendors, saying that devotees visiting a nearby temple had been complaining about the "stinky meat smells". By the next day, though, the mahant had had a change of heart (perhaps the backlash on social media had something to do with it), issuing an apology and the usual blandishments about taking "everyone along". Hope the truce holds...

Kaushik Deka with Suhani Singh, Jumana Shah and Dhaval S. Kulkarni